

7.3

Using your voice

- A** To make your presentation interesting and easy to understand you must use your voice well. Listen to your teacher read this first extract from a presentation, then practise reading it yourself.

Good morning ladies and gentlemen. // I'm very glad to be here today // to have the chance // to tell you about our company. // Our company was founded // in nineteen fifty eight // as a small family business. // Today it employs // more than four hundred and sixty people, // and it has an annual turnover // of two hundred million dollars. // What are the reasons // for this outstanding growth? // The reasons are: // the quality of our products, // our attention to the needs of our customers, // and our decentralized management structure. // This structure allows: // flexibility, // motivation // and the rapid development of new ideas.

- B** Now follow this procedure for the paragraph in the box below from the same presentation.

- 1 Decide where you would pause and put a // symbol. Pauses allow you to break the information into small pieces that the audience can understand more easily.
- 2 Underline the syllables that have a strong stress. Inside each phrase you have marked there will be some syllables with a strong beat. Important words will always have a strongly stressed syllable.
- 3 Check if there are any words that are difficult to say. If there are, write the phonetic script with the help of a dictionary or put a ■ symbol above a stressed syllable.

As you know, we specialize in electrical distribution systems, and our company is well-known for having the widest product range in the market. The key philosophy behind our products is ease of assembly, and indeed we are regarded as the leader in this field. Our product system remains totally flexible until the final installation at the construction site. And where are the construction sites? You'll find our products in every type of property, from residential developments and office blocks to factories and industrial units.

- 4 Practise reading the text several times. Use your voice to make the information as clear as possible. There are three main things to practise:
 - Pausing at the // symbols so that the message has maximum impact. Practice pausing for two seconds, because this will help you to make pausing into a habit.
 - Emphasizing key words by pausing just before them, or saying them with more force, or more slowly, or with a higher voice.
 - Using the intonation of your voice to show if an idea is finished: a fall-rise at the end of a phrase shows the idea is not yet finished, a fall at the end shows it is.

- C** Follow the same procedure 1–4 for the next paragraph from the same presentation.

OK, that's all I want to say about our product range. Now I'd like to say a few words about our market. Who exactly are our customers? Well, we sell more than seventy percent of our products through wholesalers, and the rest directly to builders. I'd also like to remind you that more than thirty percent of our production goes for export. We view our customers not just as customers – we view them as partners. Partners who can work with us to innovate and set new standards for electrical distribution systems.